

Profile

We got **NISSAR ALI CHIKATE** to give us a professional's opinion on the speakers we tested. He started out as an assistant engineer for *Akashwani*, Mumbai in 1989. He then joined *Radio Mid-Day* as production engineer



in 1995. He is now the technical-in charge (station engineer) of Go 92.5 FM—Radio Mid-Day's new avatar. Well-known in the recording industry, he was responsible for a live broadcast of the Zubin Mehta concert on AIR FM from the Brabourne Stadium.

the Artis S400 lead the pack. Following closely were the Odyssey and the Creative. The Artis S800 was surprisingly behind the S400 in terms of performance, although it is priced about 600 rupees more than the S400. The Frontech did a pretty good rendition of the Hindi songs—especially the classical piece, *Rachna Teen Taal*, by Ustad Amjad Ali Khan—where it held its own against the biggies. In fact, it beat the Inspire, and was second only to the S400.

The Inspire clearly led the pack in the DVD-Audio tests, with richer and distinctive sound. The Philips was another set of speakers that excelled in the DVD-Audio department. Surprisingly, the Philips sound much better when DVD content—movies or music—is played.

The Typhoon and the Intex were just in the wrong league here, and were disappointing. What sounded like a bass drum on the Creative or Philips set, sounded like someone kicking a tin-can on the Intex IT3000W.

In our audio frequency file tests, there was a wide spectrum of variance among the speakers. The Intex IT3000W

scored the lowest, while the S400 was the winner in the tests. The overall bass champion's crown was shared by the S400 and Creative. The Altec Lansing was the winner in the overall treble scores, followed closely by the Creative, Artis S400, S800, Frontech and the Odyssey.

Creative Inspire 4400



Lord of the sounds

The Creative Inspire 4400 has a sub-woofer that comprises a wooden enclosure finished in black. A thin black veil protects the woofer cone from dust.

A small-wired remote control lets you handle the volume. The sub-woofer has a rather discouraging bass control knob—you have to bend your back to access it. Unlike other Creative speakers, this set is powered by a small, neat-looking power adapter. The long wires allow you to place the speakers at the right distance.

On the performance front, the only speaker set that completely outshone the Inspire 4400 was the Altec Lansing 641. The Inspire 440 was a great sport in the gaming arena. The bass was undistorted, and the punch, tight. The highs were clear and distinct. It hit a similar note in the music tests. The effects in the DVD test, though, not all that inspiring, were better than the crowd. The speaker response is true to the input, until the 75 per cent mark of the volume level. Push it beyond that, and distortions and sound clipping from the woofer gets noticed.

Priced at Rs 3,500, the Inspire 4400 provides a bang for the buck as far as 4.1 sets are concerned. Therefore, geeks and gals, we are pleased to crown the Creative Inspire 4400 as our performance winner.



Creative Inspire 4400

B-

Price: Rs 3,500
+ Good response
- Slightly under-powered sub-woofer

Performance	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶
Features	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶
Build quality	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶
Value for money	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶

// The reproduction of low bass, as well as the upper highs is good. It gives dynamic image for overall sound. Though the wattage rating in total is only 41 W, they deliver more fuller sound. I enjoyed them //

— NISSAR ALI CHIKATE

Overall Movie Performance

Scale of 5

